

LAST SEEN ONLINE

Written by
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Original Screenplay

FADE IN:

INT. AARAV'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

Complete darkness except for a single rectangle of cold blue light – a phone screen glowing like an ember that refuses to die. The room around it barely exists. A desk lost under textbooks. A half-eaten packet of biscuits. An unwashed coffee mug. The kind of room that hasn't been cleaned because its inhabitant has forgotten, or stopped caring, that the world still requires upkeep.

We hear the soft, rhythmic percussion of thumbs on glass. Careful. Deliberate. Like a prayer being composed.

INSERT – PHONE SCREEN:

A chat window. The contact name reads: Aarohi ♥■
Below the name, in small grey text: Last seen: 2 months ago. A message being typed, letter by careful letter: "I passed by that café today... the one you loved. They still have that terrible playlist you pretended to hate but always hummed along to."

SEND. A single grey tick. Delivered. The screen waits. We wait. Nothing comes back.

The phone is lowered. We see him now – AARAV (22), sitting cross-legged on his bed. He might have been handsome once. He still is, technically – good bone structure under days of stubble, dark eyes that were probably bright once. But grief has moved in behind those eyes and dimmed everything like a bulb left on too long.

He scrolls up. The messages stretch back for months. Years, maybe.

INSERT – PHONE SCREEN (SCROLLING UPWARD):

Voice notes with waveforms like little heartbeats. Strings of laughing emojis – the kind you only send

when something is genuinely funny, not just mildly amusing. A blurry photo of rain on a window captioned "us every monsoon ■■". A screenshot of a meme he'd sent her at 2am with her reply: "aarav i have an exam tomorrow why are you like this". A selfie she sent. She's laughing, eyes almost shut. She looks impossibly alive.

He stops scrolling. Stares at that photo for a long moment.

Then he types again.

INSERT:

"You still owe me that coffee, you know. I'm adding interest."

Send. The tick appears. Grey. Alone. He locks the phone and sets it on the pillow beside him. Not on the nightstand. The pillow. As close to him as it can be.

FLASH CUT TO:

EXT. OLD CITY STREET - EVENING (MEMORY)

Golden hour. The kind of light that makes everything look like it belongs in a film – which it does now, which it always will. The street is crowded but AARAV and AAROHI (21) exist in their own pocket of atmosphere.

AAROHI is laughing so hard she's had to stop walking. She has a way of laughing with her whole body – head thrown back, hand on his arm for balance. AARAV watches her the way people watch sunsets. Aware that it will end. Not wanting it to.

AAROHI

(gasping, pointing)

That man's dog is wearing SHOES,
Aarav. Little red shoes. I am not
emotionally prepared for this.

AARAV

You're crying. You're literally crying over dog shoes.

AAROHI

They're red! They match his little bandana! This is the single greatest thing I've ever seen in my life!

AARAV

(softly, not looking at the dog)

Yeah. Me too.

She catches him looking at her instead of the dog. She shoves his shoulder.

AAROHI

Stop being so... you. It's embarrassing.

AARAV

You love it.

AAROHI

(not denying it)

Buy me coffee and I'll consider not hating you.

AARAV

I literally bought you coffee an hour ago.

AAROHI

Future coffee. You owe me future coffee. It's a debt now.

She starts walking again, still giggling. He follows.

He watches the back of her head. The way she moves. Memorizing, though he doesn't know that's what he's doing yet.

BACK TO PRESENT:

INT./EXT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - DAYS PASSING (MONTAGE)

Time does what time does. It keeps moving even when you beg it to stop.

— Aarav on a crowded DTC bus, standing, one hand on the overhead rail, the other thumb-typing. His face blank with the particular blankness of someone who has removed themselves from their surroundings.

INSERT:

"It rained today. Properly. You would've made me stand outside in it."

— The same café from the memory. Aarav sits across from an empty chair. A single cup of chai in front of him. The chair across: bare. He has not ordered anything for the empty seat, but it feels like he almost did.

INSERT:

"I got the Sharma & Co. internship. The one we both applied for. I don't know how to feel about that."

— 3am. The bedroom. Aarav staring at the ceiling fan. The phone resting on his chest, rising and falling with his breath.

INSERT:

"I wish you were here. I'm tired of saying it but I don't know what else to say. I just do."

All messages: delivered. No replies. Grey ticks. Always grey.

END MONTAGE.

INT. AARAV'S BEDROOM - 2:47 AM

The room is the darkest it's been. The phone screen off. Aarav lies flat on his back, eyes open, studying the ceiling like it owes him something. He hasn't moved in a while.

His lips part. No sound comes out. He closes them. Tries again.

AARAV

(to the ceiling, barely audible)

Aarohi. If you can hear this somehow. I don't know. I know that's not how it works. I just... I want you to know I haven't stopped. Talking to you. I can't stop.

Silence. The fan turns slowly overhead.

His phone BUZZES.

He doesn't move. It buzzes again. He lies very still, like sudden movement might cause something fragile to shatter.

Then – slow, the way you approach something you're afraid to scare away – he picks it up.

INSERT – PHONE SCREEN:

The chat window. Aarohi ♥■ At the bottom, where there was nothing: a message. A small grey bubble. Three words: "I saw it."

Aarav sits up so fast the room seems to tilt. He reads it again. Holds the phone closer, as if proximity will make it more real or less real, he isn't sure which he wants.

AARAV

(barely breathing)

No. No no no. What–

His hands are shaking. He can see the tremor in the phone. He watches it like it might disappear if he blinks.

He types. Deletes. Types again.

INSERT:

"Who is this?"

Send. He waits. He's forgotten to breathe.

Three dots appear. Typing. Typing. Stop. Then:

INSERT:

"You know me."

AARAV

(standing now, moving
to the wall, back
against it)

Okay. Okay, someone has her
phone. Someone hacked it, or—
this is a prank, this is someone
being cruel, this is—

He calls the number. His finger stabs the call icon.

INSERT – PHONE SCREEN:

CALLING: Aarohi ♥■ ... Connecting...

It rings once. Half a ring. Then – silence. Call ended.

AARAV

(pulling the phone
away, staring at it)

Don't. Don't you dare—

He calls again.

INSERT:

The number you are calling is switched off.

The phone BUZZES in his hand.

INSERT:

"Don't call."

He slides down the wall until he's sitting on the floor.
Back against it, knees up, phone gripped between both
hands. He's past fear. He's somewhere past fear that
doesn't have a clean name yet.

AARAV

(voice cracking)
Who are you? Why would you do
this? Do you have any idea what—
do you know what this is doing to
me right now?

He types it. Sends it. Then, immediately after:

INSERT:

"Stop this. Please. I'm begging you. This isn't
funny. This is not funny."

The reply is instantaneous, like it was already written,
waiting:

INSERT:

"Why do you still text me, Aarav?"

His name. She used his name. He breaks before he can stop
it – not a sob, something worse: a sharp, silent collapse.
His head drops forward. His shoulders shake once. The
phone slips from his grip onto the floor.

He picks it up again. Can't let go.

AARAV

(voice gone hollow)
Because. I... because.

He closes his eyes. Speaks to the empty room.

AARAV (CONT'D)

Because I don't know how to stop.
Because I sit down for dinner and
I think of something to tell you
and then I remember. I remember
every single time and it keeps
happening, it keeps being new.
And texting you is the only way I
know how to – I don't know. Keep
you somewhere.

He types, slower now. Honestly now.

INSERT:

"Because you never said goodbye. And neither did I."

He sends it. His eyes are wet. He doesn't wipe them.

A pause. Longer this time. Long enough that he thinks it's over.

Then:

INSERT:

"You were there, Aarav. At the end. You were there."

Everything stops.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - NIGHT (MEMORY - SIX MONTHS AGO)

The white is aggressive here. Fluorescent light. The smell of antiseptic trying to cover up the smell of something else. Machines. Too many machines for one small person.

AAROHI lies in the bed. She looks smaller than she is. Or smaller than she was. There are tubes. Her parents sit on the other side, exhausted into stillness, holding each other's hands.

AARAV stands near the door. He has been here for six hours. He could not make himself come closer than the door. He has been telling himself he'll go to her in a moment. In a moment. In a moment.

Her eyes open. Just briefly. They find him.

She can't really move. But her eyes – her eyes say something.

He takes one step toward her. Then another. He is at the bedside now. He takes her hand, careful of the IV. Her fingers are cold. He wraps both his hands around hers.

AARAV

(wrecked, barely
holding)

Hey. I'm here. I'm right here.
You don't have to – you don't
have to do anything. I'm just
here.

Her mouth moves. No sound.

AARAV (CONT'D)

(leaning closer)

I can't hear you. Aarohi, I
can't–

But he can see what she's doing. She's smiling. Faint.
Real. The kind of smile that costs something.

Her eyes close.

The machines change their sound. The room changes. Aarav
doesn't let go of her hand.

He doesn't say anything. He just holds on.

BACK TO PRESENT:

INT. AARAV'S BEDROOM – CONTINUOUS

Aarav is crying now. Fully. Not the polite kind – the kind
that takes over your breathing, the kind you haven't
allowed yourself in a long time because you were afraid
that if you started, you'd never find the walls of it.

AARAV

(gasping, to himself,
to her)

I was there. I was there and I
didn't say it. I didn't say any
of it. I just – I held your hand
and I thought there'd be more
time, I kept thinking, just a few
more seconds, just – and then
there wasn't. There wasn't.

He types through the blur.

INSERT:

"I should've said more. I had so many things and I just stood there. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry."

Send. He waits.

Typing...

INSERT:

"You said everything. I heard it. Not the words. You."

Aarav presses the phone against his chest. Closes his eyes. Breathes – or tries to. His body is shaking with the effort of processing something too large to fit inside one human being.

AARAV

(whispering)

I miss you. I miss you so much
it's physical. It's like – it's
like a bruise. Everywhere.

He types it. Just those words.

INSERT:

"I miss you."

Send.

He waits. The cursor blinks in the chat window. Nothing. He wipes his face with the back of his wrist. Waits more.

He looks at the contact header.

INSERT:

Last seen: just now.

He blinks. Reads it again.

Then – he watches as the words change, right in front of him, like a timestamp being corrected, like a record being set straight:

INSERT:

Last seen: Never.

He stares. His brow furrows. He pulls the screen closer.
Refreshes. Still the same.

AARAV

(confused, soft)

What does that... what does that
mean?

The phone BUZZES. Final message.

INSERT:

"You have to let me go now, Aarav. Not because you
love me less. Because you loved me right."

The silence that follows is different from all the other
silences tonight. This one doesn't feel empty. It feels
like the moment after a song ends – when the sound is gone
but the music is still somehow in the room.

Aarav sits with it. He doesn't move. He lets the quiet be
what it is.

Then, slowly, he opens the keyboard.

He types something. Deletes it.

Types again.

"I don't know how."

Delete.

"Not yet."

Delete.

He stays with the blank text field for a long time.

Then:

INSERT:

"Goodbye."

He stares at the word. Just one word. Everything in it.

He hits send.

The message goes. He watches the tick. One tick. Just one. Grey and alone.

He taps the contact name. Profile page. Where her number was: "No longer available."

He looks at that for a long moment. Then he sets the phone face-down on the floor beside him. Keeps his hand on it for a moment, palm flat against the back of it. Like a small goodbye of its own.

Then he lets go.

He leans his head back against the wall. Eyes closed. Still crying, but it's quieter now. Softer. Grief can sound like many things. This sounds like the tide going out.

FADE TO:

EXT. OLD CITY STREET - EARLY MORNING

First light. The city is still choosing between night and day. The street from the memory – same cobblestones, same shopfronts, but the golden hour is replaced by something cooler. More honest. The light that shows things as they are.

AARAV walks. He has showered, it looks like. Shaved, maybe halfway. He is not healed – let's not pretend that's how this works. But he is upright. He is walking. That is not a small thing.

He slows as he reaches the café. It's just opening – a boy rolling up the shutter, the smell of fresh bread and something frying already on the air.

Aarav stops outside. Looks in through the glass. The tables are empty. The morning light falls across them cleanly.

He looks at the table in the corner. Her table. The one she always claimed was the best in the house because you could see both the street AND the counter, which meant maximum people-watching potential.

He almost smiles. A small almost-smile. The kind that acknowledges beauty and grief existing in the same moment, because they always do.

He reaches into his pocket. Takes out his phone. He looks at it for a moment – its blank, dark screen.

He doesn't open it.

He puts it back.

AARAV

(quietly, to the empty
morning)

I'll have your coffee. On your
tab.

He pushes open the café door. A small bell jingles above him. He goes inside.

The door swings shut behind him. Through the glass, we see him walk to the counter. Talk to someone. Almost smile again.

Through the glass, from outside: he sits down at her table. Sets his phone face-down on the surface. And looks out the window at the street.

He is present. He is here. He is continuing.

The street outside fills slowly with morning.

15.

FADE OUT.

THE END

– Written by Nishant –